

Note values

The time value of a note is relative to that of other notes. Rhythms are created when patterns of longer or shorter notes are played or sung against the background of the steady pulse and meter.

SEE ALSO

◀ 18–19 Notes on the staff

Beams and dots 28–29 ▶

Time signatures 30–31 ▶

Tempo 44–45 ▶

Time values of notes

Here are the five most common note values. Notice how they are drawn—whether the note head is filled in, if there is a note stem, or if there is a tail or flag (see p.28) attached to the stem. You could practice writing these on a sheet of music paper, taking care to put the note head clearly on a line or in a space.



△ Whole note

This is a long note, equal to four quarter notes. The note head is not filled in and there is no stem.



△ Half note

A half note has half the time value of a whole note, and twice the value of a quarter note.



△ Quarter note

A very common time value, a quarter note is often the note value chosen for the beat.



△ Eighth note

Equal to half a quarter note, an eighth note is distinguished by its tail or flag.



△ Sixteenth note

A sixteenth note is short, half as long as an eighth. It has two tails or flags joined to the stem.

Tempo

Note values are not measured in an absolute way. A quarter note may last a long time if the tempo is slow, or a short time if the tempo is fast. “Tempo” is the word used to describe the speed of the music. The same rhythm may be played fast or slow, depending on the tempo.



△ Tempo indication

This rhythm could be played both fast or slow. Until we add a tempo indication (see p.44), we cannot tell simply from the way this is written.

LOOKING CLOSER

Other note values

Apart from the common note values shown above, you may also come across longer notes such as a double whole note or shorter ones such as a thirty-second note, or even a sixty-fourth.



△ Double whole note

Twice as long as a whole note, this is rarely encountered.



△ Thirty-second note

A thirty-second note is a short note, half as long as a sixteenth.



△ Sixty-fourth note

A sixty-fourth note is even shorter—half as long as a thirty-second.